

The Chromatic Polynomials and its Algebraic Properties

B.R. Srinivas

Associate Professor of Mathematics,
 St. Marys Group of Institutions Guntur, A.P, INDIA
 brsmastan@gmail.com

A. Sri Krishna Chaitanya

Associate Professor of Mathematics,
 Chebrolu Engineering College, Guntur. A.P, INDIA
 askc_7@yahoo.com

Abstract: *This paper studies various results on chromatic polynomials of graphs. We obtain results on the roots of chromatic polynomials of planar graphs. The main results are chromatic polynomial of a graph is polynomial in integer and the leading coefficient of chromatic polynomial of a graph of order n and size m is one, whose coefficient alternate in sign. Mathematics subject classification 2000: 05CXX, 05C15, 05C30, 05C75*

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1. INTRODUCTION

During the period that the Four Color Problem was unsolved, which spanned more than a century, many approaches were introduced with the hopes that they would lead to a solution of this famous problem. In 1912 George David Birkhoff [5] defined a function $P(M, \lambda)$ that gives the number of proper λ -colorings of a map M for a positive integer λ . As we will see, $P(M, \lambda)$ is a polynomial in λ for every map M and is called the chromatic polynomial of M . Consequently, if it could be verified that $P(M, 4) > 0$ for every map M , then this would have established the truth of the Four Color Conjecture.

In 1932 Hassler Whitney [14] expanded the study of chromatic polynomials from maps to graphs. While Whitney obtained a number of results on chromatic polynomials of graphs, this did not contribute to a proof of the Four Color Conjecture. Renewed interest in chromatic polynomials of graphs occurred in 1968 when Ronald C. Read [13] wrote a survey paper on chromatic polynomials.

2. PRELIMINARIES

2.1. Definition: For a graph G and a positive integer λ the number of different proper λ -colorings of G is denoted by $P(G, \lambda)$ and is called the **Chromatic Polynomial** of G . Two λ -colorings c and c' of G from the same set $\{1, 2, \dots, \lambda\}$ of λ colors are considered different if $c(v) \neq c'(v)$ for some vertex v of G . Obviously, if $\lambda < \chi(G)$, then $P(G, \lambda) = 0$. By convention, $P(G, 0) = 0$. Indeed, we have the following.

2.2. Proposition: Let G be a graph. Then $\chi(G) = k$ if and only if k is the smallest positive integer for which $P(G, k) > 0$.

As an example, we determine the number of ways that the vertices of the graph G of Figure.1 can be colored from the set $\{1, 2, 3, 4, 5\}$. The vertex v can be assigned any of these 5 colors, while w can be assigned any color other than the color assigned to v . That is, w can be assigned any of the 4 remaining colors. Both u and t can be assigned any of the 3 colors not used for v and w . Therefore, the number $P(G, 5)$ of 5-colorings of G is $5 \cdot 4 \cdot 3 = 180$. More

generally, $P(G, \lambda) = \lambda(\lambda - 1)(\lambda - 2)^2$ for every integer λ .

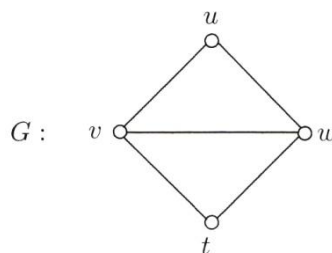


Figure 1. A graph G with $P(G, \lambda) = \lambda(\lambda - 1)(\lambda - 2)^2$

There are some classes of graphs G for which $P(G, \lambda)$ can be easily computed.

3. CHROMATIC POLYNOMIALS

3.1.Theorem: For every positive integer λ

(a) $P(K_n, \lambda) = \lambda(\lambda - 1)(\lambda - 2)\dots(\lambda - n + 1) = \lambda^{(n)}$

(b) $P(K_n, \lambda) = \lambda^n$

Proof: In particular, if $\lambda \geq n$ in Theorem 2(a), then

$$P(K_n, \lambda) = \lambda^{(n)} = \frac{\lambda!}{(\lambda - n)!}$$

We now determine the chromatic polynomial of C_4 in Figure 2. There are λ choices for the color of v_1 . The vertices v_2 and v_4 must be assigned colors different from the assigned to v_1 . The vertices v_2 and v_4 may be assigned the same color or may be assigned different colors. If v_2 and v_4 are assigned the same color, then there are $\lambda - 1$ choices for that color. The vertex v_3 can then be assigned any color except the color assigned to v_2 and v_4 . Hence the number of distinct λ -colorings of C_4 in which v_2 and v_4 are colored the same is $\lambda(\lambda - 1)^2$.

If, on the other hand, v_2 and v_4 are colored differently, then there are $\lambda - 1$ choices for v_2 and $\lambda - 2$ choices for v_4 . Since v_3 can be assigned any color except the two colors assigned to v_2 and v_4 , the number of λ -colorings of C_4 in which v_2

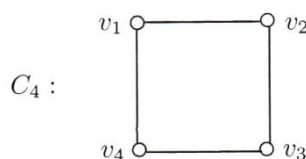


Figure 2. The chromatic polynomial of C_4

and v_4 are colored differently is $\lambda(\lambda - 1)(\lambda - 2)^2$. Hence the number of distinct λ -colorings of C_4 is

$$\begin{aligned} P(C_4, \lambda) &= \lambda(\lambda - 1)^2 + \lambda(\lambda - 1)(\lambda - 2)^2 \\ &= \lambda(\lambda - 1)(\lambda^2 - 3\lambda + 3) \\ &= \lambda^4 - 4\lambda^3 + 6\lambda^2 - 3\lambda \\ &= (\lambda - 1)^4 + (\lambda - 1) \end{aligned}$$

The preceding example illustrates an important observation. Suppose that u and v are nonadjacent vertices in a graph G . The number of λ -colorings of G equals the number of λ -colorings of G in which u and v are colored differently plus the number of λ -colorings of G in which u and v are colored the same. Since the number of λ -colorings of G in which u and v are colored differently is the number of λ -colorings of $G + uv$ while the number of λ -colorings of G in which u and v are colored the same is the number of λ -colorings of the

graph H obtained by identifying u and v (an elementary homomorphism), it follows that

$$P(G, \lambda) = P(G + uv, \lambda) + P(H, \lambda)$$

This observation is summarized below by Erdos, R.J.Wilson [8], chromatic index of graphs.

3.2. Theorem: Let G be a graph containing nonadjacent vertices u and v and let H be the graph obtained from G by identifying u and v . Then

$$P(G, \lambda) = P(G + uv, \lambda) + P(H, \lambda)$$

Proof: Note that if G is a graph of order $n \geq 2$ and size $m \geq 1$, then $G + uv$ has order n and size $m+1$ while H has order $n - 1$ and size at most m . The equation stated in Theorem 2.1 can also be expressed as

$$P(G + uv, \lambda) = P(G, \lambda) - P(H, \lambda)$$

In this context, Theorem 2.1 can be rephrased in terms of an edge deletion and an elementary contraction.

3.3. Corollary: Let G be a graph containing adjacent vertices u and v and let F be the graph obtained from G by identifying u and v . Then

$$P(G, \lambda) = P(G - uv, \lambda) - P(F, \lambda)$$

Proof: By systematically applying Theorem 2.1 to pairs of nonadjacent vertices in a graph G , we eventually arrive at a collection of complete graphs. We now illustrate this. Suppose that we wish to compute the chromatic polynomial of the graph G of Figure 3. For the nonadjacent vertices u and v of G and the graph H obtained by identifying u and v , it follows that by Theorem 2.1 that the chromatic polynomial of G is the sum of the chromatic polynomials of $G + uv$ and H .

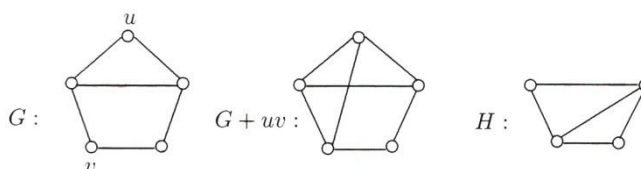
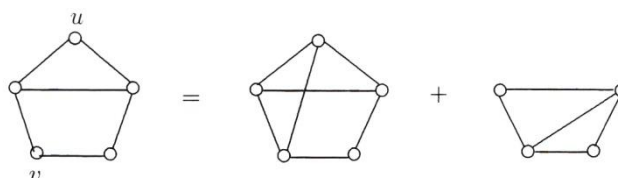


Figure 3

At this point it is useful to adopt a convention introduced by Alexander Zykov [15] and utilized later by Ronald Read [9]. Rather than repeatedly writing the equation that appears in the statement of Theorem 2.1, we represent the chromatic polynomial of a graph by a drawing of the graph and indicate on the drawing which pair u, v of nonadjacent vertices will be separately joined by an edge and identified. So, for the graph G of Figure 3, we have Continuing in this manner, as shown in Figure 4, we obtain



$$P(G, \lambda) = \lambda^5 - 6\lambda^4 + 14\lambda^3 - 15\lambda^2 + 6\lambda$$

Using this approach, we see that the chromatic polynomial of every graph is the sum of chromatic polynomials of complete graphs. A consequence of this observation is the following.

3.4. Theorem: The chromatic polynomial $P(G, \lambda)$ of a graph G is a polynomial in λ .

Proof. There are some interesting properties possessed by the chromatic polynomial of every graph. In fact, if G is a graph of order n and size m , then the chromatic polynomial

$P(G, \lambda)$ of G can be expressed as

$$P(G, \lambda) = c_0 \lambda^n + c_1 \lambda^{n-1} + c_2 \lambda^{n-2} + \dots + c_{n-1} \lambda + c_n$$

$$= \lambda^{(5)} + 4\lambda^{(4)} + 3\lambda^{(3)} = \lambda^5 - 6\lambda^4 + 14\lambda^3 - 15\lambda^2 + 6\lambda$$

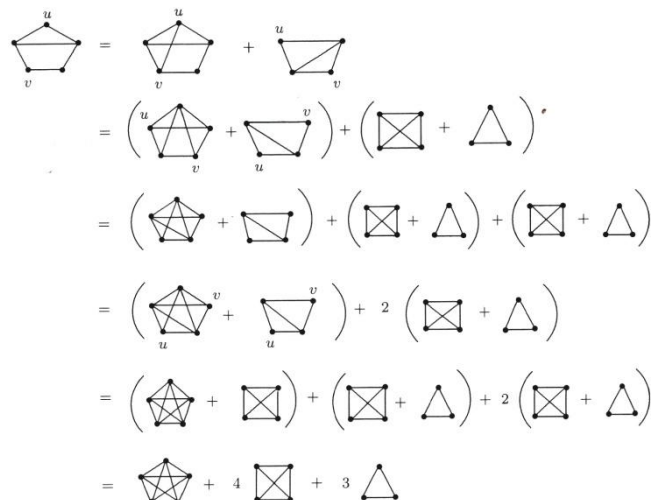


Figure 5. $P(G, \lambda) = P(G + uv, \lambda) + P(H, \lambda)$

Where $c_0 = 1$ ($P(G, \lambda)$ is a polynomial of degree n with leading coefficient 1), $c_1 = -m$, $c_i \geq 0$ if i is even with $0 \leq i \leq n$, and $c_i \leq 0$ if i is odd with $1 \leq i \leq n$. Since $P(G, 0) = 0$, it follows that $c_n = 0$.

3.5. Theorem: Let G be a graph of order n and size m . Then $P(G, \lambda)$ is a polynomial of degree n with leading coefficient 1 such that the coefficient of λ^{n-1} is $-m$, and whose coefficients alternate in sign.

Proof: We proceed by induction on m . If $m = 0$, then $G = \overline{K_n}$ and $P(G, \lambda) = \lambda^n$, as we have seen. Then $P(\overline{K_n}, \lambda) = \lambda^n$ has the desired properties.

Assume that the result holds for all graphs whose size is less than m , where $m \geq 1$. Let G be a graph of order m and let $e = uv$ an edge of G . By Corollary 2.2,

$$P(G, \lambda) = P(G - e, \lambda) - P(F, \lambda),$$

Where F is the graph obtained from G by identifying u and v . Since $G - e$ has order n and size $m - 1$, it follows by the induction hypothesis that

$$P(G - e, \lambda) = a_0 \lambda^n + a_1 \lambda^{n-1} + a_2 \lambda^{n-2} + \dots + a_{n-1} \lambda + a_n,$$

Where $a_0 = 1$, $a_1 = -(m-1)$, $a_i \geq 0$ if i is even with $0 \leq i \leq n$, $a_i \leq 0$ if i is odd with $1 \leq i \leq n$. Furthermore, since F has order $n-1$ and size m' , where $m' \leq m-1$, it follows that

$$P(F, \lambda) = b_0 \lambda^{n-1} + b_1 \lambda^{n-2} + b_2 \lambda^{n-3} + \dots + b_{n-2} \lambda + b_{n-1},$$

Where $b_0 = 1$, $b_1 = -m'$, $b_i \geq 0$ if i is even with $0 \leq i \leq n-1$, and $b_i \leq 0$ if i is odd with $1 \leq i \leq n-1$. By Corollary

$$P(G, \lambda) = P(G - e, \lambda) - P(F, \lambda)$$

$$= (a_0 \lambda^n + a_1 \lambda^{n-1} + a_2 \lambda^{n-2} + \dots + a_{n-1} \lambda + a_n) -$$

$$(b_0 \lambda^{n-1} + b_1 \lambda^{n-2} + b_2 \lambda^{n-3} + \dots + b_{n-2} \lambda + b_{n-1})$$

$$= a_0 \lambda^n + (a_1 - b_0) \lambda^{n-1} + (a_2 - b_1) \lambda^{n-2} + \dots + (a_{n-1} - b_{n-2}) \lambda + (a_n - b_{n-1})$$

Since $a_0 = 1$, $a_1 - b_0 = -(m-1) - 1 = -m$, $a_i - b_{i-1} \geq 0$ if i is even with $2 \leq i \leq n$, and $a_i - b_{i-1} \leq 0$ if i is odd with $0 \leq i \leq n$, $P(G, \lambda)$ has the desired properties and the theorem follows by mathematical induction.

Suppose that a graph G contains an end-vertex v whose only neighbor is u . Then, of course, $P(G-v, \lambda)$ is the number of λ -colorings of $G-v$. The vertex v can then be assigned any of the λ colors except the color assigned to u . This observation gives the following.

3.6. Theorem: If G is a graph containing an end-vertex v , then

$$P(G, \lambda) = (\lambda - 1) P(G - v, \lambda)$$

One consequence of this result is the following.

3.7. Corollary: If T is a tree of order $n \geq 1$, then

$$P(T, \lambda) = \lambda (\lambda - 1)^{n-1}$$

Proof: We proceed by induction on n . For $n = 1$, $T = K_1$ and certainly $P(K_1, \lambda) = \lambda$. Thus the basis step of the induction is true. Suppose that $P(T', \lambda) = \lambda(\lambda-1)^{n-2}$ for every tree T' of order $n-1 \geq 1$ and let T be a tree of order n . Let v be an end-vertex of T . Thus $T-v$ is a tree of order $n-1$. By Theorem 3.2 and the induction hypothesis

$$P(T, \lambda) = (\lambda - 1)P(T - v, \lambda) = (\lambda - 1)[\lambda(\lambda - 1)^{n-2}] = \lambda(\lambda - 1)^{n-1} \text{ as desired.}$$

Two graphs are chromatically equivalent if they have the same chromatic polynomial.

In this section we'll summarize some well-known facts about the chromatic polynomial's coefficients, roots and substitutions as well as their relations to some graph-theoretic properties of G .

4. COEFFICIENTS OF THE CHROMATIC POLYNOMIALS

Claim 3.1: The lead coefficient of $\text{chr}(G, k)$ is always 1.

Proof: Use the partitioning argument from theorem 2.5. The only partition that contributes to the lead coefficient is the one with n parts, giving an addend of $k(k-1)\dots(k-n+1)$ where the coefficient of k^n is 1.

Claim 3.2: The coefficient of k^{n-1} in $\text{chr}(G, k)$ is the negative of the number of edges.

Proof: Apply the deletion-contraction argument. By contracting an edge we obtain a graph on $n-1$ vertices, whose chromatic polynomial has 1 as the coefficient of k^{n-1} according to our previous claim. Therefore deleting the edge should augment the coefficient of k^{n-1} by 1, finally reaching in zero as all edges are removed. So initially it had to be the negative of the number of edges.

Claim 3.3: The constant term, i.e. the coefficient of 1 in $\text{chr}(G, k)$ is always zero.

Proof: Substituting $k = 0$ into the chromatic polynomial yields 0 since G cannot be colored using 0 colors.

Claim 3.4: The coefficient of k in $\text{chr}(G, k)$ is non-zero if and only if G is connected.

Proof: We know that the chromatic polynomial of a disconnected graph is the product of that of its components. If we have at least two terms, each being divisible by k , then their product is divisible by k^2 , thus its coefficient of k is zero.

For connected graphs we'll prove the slightly stronger result that the coefficient of k is positive if n is odd and negative if n is even. This works by induction based on the deletion-contraction argument. We can always select an edge that is not a bridge unless the graph is a tree. otherwise both deletion and contraction gives a connected graph so we may continue the induction.

Lemma 3.5: Let $c(F)$ denote the number of components in a spanning subgraph F . Then

$$\text{chr}(G, k) = \sum_{F \subseteq E(G)} (-1)^{|F|} k^{c(F)}$$

Proof: The number of ways we may assign colors to $V(G)$ so that vertices connected by F -edges do share the same color is $k^{c(F)}$. This is the number of colorings that *violate* the vertex coloring

condition for all edges in F . Since the chromatic polynomial counts the colorings that violate this condition for no edges in $E(G)$, the result follows from the principle of inclusion-exclusion.

Claim 3.6: The coefficients of the chromatic polynomial alternate in sign. That is, for the coefficient a_m of k^m we have $a_m \geq 0$ if $n \equiv m(2)$ and $a_m \leq 0$ otherwise.

Proof: The claim holds for the empty graph and is preserved during a deletion-contraction step.

Claim 3.7: For a connected graph G the coefficients satisfy.

$$1 = |a_n| < |a_{n-1}| < \cdots < \left| a_{\lfloor \frac{n}{2} \rfloor + 1} \right|$$

Proof: We would like to show $|a_{m+1}| < |a_m|$ for $m > \frac{n}{2}$.

For trees we have $\text{chr}(T_n, k) = k(k-1)^{n-1}$ from section 1.4, so $a_m = (-1)^{n-m} \binom{n-1}{m-1}$ and thus the claim is $\binom{n-1}{m} < \binom{n-1}{m-1}$. Rearranging transforms this to $n-m < m$ which we have assumed.

Otherwise we may select a non-bridge edge as in the proof of claim 3.4 and apply deletion-contraction. Our previous claim tells us that the corresponding coefficients of $\text{chr}(G \setminus e, k)$ and $\text{chr}(G/e, k)$ have opposite signs, and therefore their absolute values add up. For the contracted graph we have

$$0 = |a'_n| < 1 = |a'_{n-1}| < |a'_{n-2}| < \cdots < \left| a'_{\lfloor \frac{n-1}{2} \rfloor + 1} \right|,$$

where the last index is no more than $\lfloor \frac{n}{2} \rfloor + 1$, so both $G \setminus e$ and G/e satisfy the inequalities in the claim and the final addition also preserves them.

This claim is suspected to be possibly strengthened:

Conjecture 3.8: (unimodal conjecture). There exists some k such that

$$|a_n| \leq |a_{n-1}| \leq \cdots \leq |a_{k+1}| \leq |a_k| \geq |a_{k-1}| \geq \cdots \geq |a_2| \geq |a_1|$$

This claim has been verified for a few classes of graphs, but remains generally unknown. For some related results see [12].

5. ROOTS OF CHROMATIC POLYNOMIALS

A nonnegative integer root k of the chromatic polynomial means noncolorability with k colors by definition. It follows that $k \in \mathbb{N}$ is a root if and only if $k < \chi(G)$.

Lemma 4.1: The derivative of the chromatic polynomial satisfies $(-1)^n \text{chr}'(G, 1) > 0$ for any biconnected graph and ≥ 0 for any connected graph G .

Proof: For connected graphs that are not biconnected there exists a cut vertex v and we may write the chromatic polynomial $\text{chr}(G, q)$ as a product $\frac{\text{chr}(G_1, q) \text{chr}(G_2, q)}{q}$ according to known claim.

Neither G_1 nor G_2 is empty, thus both terms have a root at 1, so 1 is at least a double root of $\text{chr}(G, q)$ and therefore its derivative also has a root at 1. It follows that the claim is satisfied with an equality.

At this point it is enough to consider biconnected graphs. For K_2 we have $\text{chr}'(K_2, 1) = 1$. Otherwise both $G \setminus e$ and G/e are connected for any edge e , so we can obtain the weaker claim by using the deletion-contraction argument. To prove the stronger one, we'll show that there exists an edge 2 for which G/e is also biconnected.

The only possible cut vertex of G/e is the contracted one, since any other vertex would also separate G . So we are looking for such an $e = ij$ that removing i and j from $V(G)$ doesn't cut G apart.

There exists a longest path in G : let i be one of its endpoints and j its neighbor. Suppose that the removal of i and j leaves a disconnected graph and pick two between the two, and they have to traverse i and j respectively. The one going through i can be used to extend the selected longest path, implying a contradiction.

Therefore if we pick e as the final segment of a longest path, G/e is also biconnected and thus the claim holds.

Claim 4.2: The chromatic polynomial has no real root greater than $n - 1$.

Proof: the chromatic polynomial is a sum of terms having the form $q(q-1)\dots(q-p+1)$ where $1 \leq p \leq n$, each of them possibly occurring multiple times. It is easy to see that such a term increases strictly monotonically for $q > n - 1 \geq p - 1$, and so does their sum as well.

Since $\text{chr}(G, q)$ is nonnegative for $q = n - 1$ and strictly increasing afterwards, it can have no root $> n - 1$.

Claim 4.3: The chromatic polynomial of a graph has no negative real roots.

Proof: By claim 3.6. we have

$$\text{chr}(G, q) = \sum_{m=1}^n a_m q^m$$

where $a_m \geq 0$ if $n \equiv m(2)$ and $a_m \leq 0$ otherwise. Thus $(-1)^n a_m q^m \geq 0$ for any $q < 0$. We also know that $a_n = 1 > 0$, and therefore $(-1)^n \text{chr}(G, q) > 0$ which implies that q cannot be a root.

Claim 4.4: The chromatic polynomial has no real roots between 0 and 1.

Proof: It suffices to deal with connected graphs. We show that $(-1)^n \text{chr}(G, q) < 0$ for any $0 < q < 1$. This statement can be easily checked for trees where $\text{chr}(G, q) = q(q-1)^{n-1}$ and otherwise it follows from the deletion-contraction property.

An extension of these claims has been proved by Jackson [13]:

Conjecture 4.5: Planar graphs have no real roots in $[4, \infty)$.

They have already solved the weaker version that $[5, \infty)$ contains no real roots. Since then, Appel and Haken have proved the four-color theorem which states that 4 is neither a root [3][4]. For the remaining interval $(4, 5)$, however, the question is still wide open.

Tutte has shown that for planar graphs $\text{chr}(G, \varphi + 2) > 0$ where $\varphi = \frac{\sqrt{5}+1}{2}$ is the golden ratio [12]. He hoped that it takes us closer to the four-color theorem since $\varphi + 2 \approx 3.618$ is close to 4, but unfortunately there are some planar graphs having a root between the two. In fact, Royle has shown that there are roots arbitrarily close to 4 from below [9].

Theorem 4.6: The roots of all chromatics polynomials are dense in $\mathbb{C}$.

Despite this claim for general graphs, there exist root-free zones if we make some restrictions. These are particularly important from the point of view of statistical mechanics.

Theorem 4.7: There exists a universal constant C such that if G has maximum degree D , then all complex roots of $\text{chr}(G, q)$ satisfy $|q| < CD$.

A similar bound $|q| < CD + 1$ exists for the second largest degree. For the third largest degree, no such claim can be made: there are arbitrarily large chromatic roots even when all except two vertices have degree 2.

6. SUBSTITUTIONS

For $k \in \mathbb{N}$ $\text{chr}(G, k)$ means the number of k -coloring of G by definition. But there are some further locations where the evaluation of the chromatic polynomial is interesting.

Claim 5.1: $|\text{chr}(G, -1)|$ gives the number of acyclic orientations of G .

Proof. Denote the number of acyclic orientations of G by $f(G)=(-1)^n \text{chr}(G, -1)$. For the empty graph we have $f(\overline{Kn})=1$ and thus the proposition holds. Now consider a nonempty graph G with an edge e selected. Suppose we have an orientation $\vec{G}_e$ on all edges except e and we would like to find out how many ways (i.e. 0,1 or 2) we can extend it to an acyclic orientation $\vec{G}$ of G .

Notice that if there exists such an acyclic extension at all, removing the edge e won't break it. On the other hand, if we can't add e in either direction because both would close a directed path in $\vec{G}_e$ into a cycle, then these two paths make up a cycle in $\vec{G}_e$ by themselves. Therefore $\vec{G}_e$ is an acyclic orientation of $G \setminus e$ if and only if e can be added in at least one direction.

$\vec{G}_e$ specifies an orientation on G/e too. If it contains a cycle passing through the contracted point, one of the two possible orientations of e will extend this cycle into a larger one. And a cycle avoiding the contracted point will be kept intact. Thus if $\vec{G}_e$ is cyclic, pointing e in at least one of the two directions will create a cycle. If $\vec{G}_e$ however, both directions of e will result in an acyclic graph, since any cycle in $\vec{G}$ would have been preserved during the contraction.

Thus if $\vec{G}_e$ specifies an acyclic orientation on 0, 1 or 2 of the graphs $G \setminus e$ and G/e , then it can be extended to G in 0, 1 or 2 ways respectively. This argument shows that $f(G)=f(G \setminus e) + f(G/e)$.

Since the same recursion holds for $f(G)$ and $(-1)^n \text{chr}(G, -1)$ and they are equal for empty graphs, they have to be always equal.

Claim 5.2: $\text{chr}'(G,0)$ returns the chromatic invariant $\beta(G)$.

Proof: The derivative of a polynomial at zero equals the linear coefficient. So the claim follows and the properties proved for $\beta(G)$ in section 3.1 apply.

The chromatic polynomial also exhibits interesting behavior at the so-called *Beraha numbers* $B_n = 2 + 2 \cos\left(\frac{2\pi}{n}\right)$, but they are outside the scope of this study.

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AUTHORS' BIOGRAPHY



Mr. B.R. Srinivas, completed his M.Sc., AO Mathematics from Acharya Nagarjuna university in the year 1995, M.Phil Mathematics from Madurai Kamaraj University in the year 2005 and M.Tech computer science engineering from Vinayaka Mission University in the year 2007. He attended for five international conferences, six faculty development programs and twenty national workshops. At present he is working as Associate Professor, St. Marys Group of Institutions Guntur, A.P, INDIA. His area of interest is graph theory and theoretical computer science.



Mr. A. Sri Krishna Chaitanya, completed his M.Sc., Mathematics from Acharya Nagarjuna university in the year 2005 and M.Phil Mathematics from Alagappa University in the year 2007. At present he is working as Associate Professor, Chebrolu Engineering College, Chebrolu, Guntur Dist, [A.P, INDIA](#). He is interested to work in the areas of Graph Theory, Boolean algebra, Lattice Theory and the Related Fields of Algebra.